

Photographs by **RANJAN RAHI**

INAUGURAL KEYNOTE ADDRESS: PUTTING BIHAR ON THE GROWTH PATH

> **"It is not possible to provide government jobs to everyone... only about 2–2.5% can be absorbed in such employment. The real answer to unemployment is self-employment"**
>
> **VIJAY KUMAR SINHA**
> **Deputy CM, Bihar**

Deputy chief minister Vijay Kumar Sinha delivered the keynote address, pointing to the rapid gains made in education and infrastructure, the tangible advances in women's empowerment and a growth strategy he argued would light Bihar's path forward. Industry minister Nitish Mishra highlighted how investment and enterprise are the engines of prosperity. Sanjay Kumar Jha, national working president of the Janata Dal (United), reiterated Nitish Kumar's pledge to create 10 million jobs within five years.

DGP Vinay Kumar offered a striking statistic on law and order—kidnapping-for-ransom cases, numbering nearly 1,000 annually two decades ago, have now come down to two dozen, many detected within hours. Chief secretary Pratyaya Amrit sketched a long view, envisaging a Viksit Bihar by 2047, in step with the national ambition of a Viksit Bharat. "We are all set; the platform is robust and, from here, we are poised to leapfrog," he said.

Also present were career bureaucrats—seven IAS and three IPS officers—who cited statistics to sketch out the improvements in road density and electrification, as well as freight and tourist corridors. Party spokespersons did what they do best—defend their models and run down their opponents'.

Actor Akhilendra Mishra rued how Bihar had stopped being a shooting destination for Bollywood, reminiscing how *Johny Mera Naam* was filmed in Rajgir, with a song featuring Dev Anand and Hema Malini. Hockey coach Harender Singh reflected on how medals can translate into livelihood security for athletes. Shailesh Kumar, gold medallist at the Para Athletics World Championship, lauded the state government's 'Medal Lao, Naukri Pao' policy as a profound inspiration for Bihar's sportspersons.

The Conclave thus unfolded as more than a showcase of achievements; it turned into a theatre of competing claims and lofty promises, each pulsing with the restless energy of Bihar's aspirations. Deputy chief minister Samrat Choudhary pledged an era of revival, citing the state's turnaround across sectors—industry now contributes 23 per cent to Bihar's GDP, he noted—significantly adding that this progress has neither been accidental nor ephemeral.The common conviction at the event was unmistakable: Bihar is no longer content to be measured against its past, but determined to script a future in step with a rising India. ■